A Note on Composing Rooms

This short document was written by hand, in plain HTML with one linked stylesheet, to see whether a printer that reads the pages an engine presented needs anything a browser would not already be given. It declares its own face, places one image, names a running head in a margin box, counts its pages at the foot, and keeps a list whose items are paragraphs.

The room

A composing room was a long hall with the cases set on frames along the windows, because the compositor needed daylight to tell one sort from the next. The upper case held the capitals and the lower case the small letters, and the names outlived the furniture by a century and a half.

Each compositor worked at a frame with a stick in the left hand, picking letters from the case with the right and setting them upside down and from left to right. A good hand could set a line of a thousand ems an hour, and

justified each line by sliding thin spaces between the words until the stick was tight.

The device stands in for a printer's mark.

When a stick was full the lines went onto a galley, a shallow tray with three raised edges, and the galley went to the proof press. The first proof was read against the copy by a reader and a copyholder, one reading aloud and the other following the type, and every error was marked in the margin with a sign the compositor would understand.

The forme

Corrected galleys were divided into pages on the imposing stone, a flat table of marble or iron. The pages were laid out in the order the folded sheet would need, surrounded by furniture of wood or metal, and locked into a chase with wedges called quoins.

The locked chase was the forme, and it was heavy enough that two people carried it to the press. A forme that was not locked evenly would spring when it was lifted, and a forme that sprang scattered a day of work across the floor.

- The furniture kept the margins: wide pieces at the foot and the fore-edge, narrow ones at the head and the gutter, so that the folded book would sit on the page as the designer meant.
- The quoins took up the slack. Driven in with a key or a mallet, they pressed the type and the furniture together until the whole forme could be lifted as one block.
- The planer levelled the face. Tapped lightly with a mallet across a wooden block, it pushed every letter down to the same height before the quoins were tightened for the last time.

The press

On the hand press the forme lay on the bed and was inked with leather balls, later with rollers of glue and treacle. The sheet was laid on the tympan, folded down under the frisket, run in beneath the platen, and pressed with a single pull of the bar.

Two people worked a press: the puller, who laid on the sheet and pulled the bar, and the beater, who inked the forme between pulls. Together they could print about two hundred and fifty sheets an hour on one side, which is why a book of any length took weeks to see through the press.

Once one side of the whole edition had been printed, the sheets were dried and the other forme was put on the press to back them up. The register between the two sides was kept by points, small pins on the tympan that pierced the sheet in the same two places on every pull.

The warehouse

Printed sheets were hung to dry on poles under the roof, then gathered in the order of their signatures, folded, collated, and sent to the binder in bundles. The warehouse kept a record of every sheet that left it, because paper was the largest single cost of a book and a missing quire was money lost.

The type itself went back to the cases. Distributing a forme, letter by letter, into the compartments it came from took almost as long as setting it, and an apprentice learned the lay of the case by doing it for years before being trusted to set.